

Really glad we got to talk.

CHARLOTTE, NC · SPARKHOUSE UPTOWN · FRI, JUL 31

What you've built at Sparkhouse is the real thing — I could feel it walking in. I run a small AI/systems shop here in Charlotte, and after we talked I couldn't stop thinking about a few things I'd noticed poking around beforehand. Figured I'd write them down in case they're useful to you.

SPEAKING OF THINGS CODE THE CITY TEACHES KIDS TO SPOT —

\$120,000_{yr}

That's what Do Greater is leaving on the table with Google's Ad Grant — free search ads for registered 501(c)(3)s. You already qualify. Kind of funny that a program built to teach that exact instinct hasn't turned it on itself yet.

IF IT'S EVER USEFUL

The Ad Grant, in three real steps

1. Sign up for Google for Nonprofits, verify through TechSoup, then apply for the Ad Grant inside that portal.
2. Wire up GA4 + Google Ads conversion tracking *before* the first campaign goes live — grant accounts get suspended for weak click-through (under 5%).
3. Build campaigns around specific programs — Start Upward enrollment, Designathon registration, Sparkhouse Coffee — not a broad "donate" ad. Specific ad groups are what keep the account healthy.

REACH

The site's slower than the mission deserves

dogreater.org runs on WordPress + Divi, shared Bluehost hosting — C- on load performance. Every extra second is a parent or a kid bouncing before they see Start Upward or Designathon registration.

DISCOVERY

Harder to find on Google than you should be

Search Console was never set up and the Google Business Profile is unclaimed. Someone searching "free entrepreneurship program for teens Charlotte" right now might not find you at all.

AUDIENCE

Your kids are on different apps than your posts are

YouTube's sitting at ~4 subscribers. No TikTok — where that exact 16-24 crowd already lives. No LinkedIn, where the corporate-sponsor conversations happen.

PIPELINE

All that foot traffic, and no way to stay in touch

20,000 square feet, Sparkhouse Coffee, the showroom floor — people move through that building every day. No signup funnel, no QR, no follow-up email turns a coffee customer into a Start Upward applicant, or a grad into a returning mentor.

None of this needs a grant or a new hire — some of it's a form and an afternoon, some of it's a Tuesday with someone who's done this before. Mostly I just wanted to write it down while it was fresh, in case any of it's useful. I love what you're building, and if there's ever a way I can actually help — not bill, just help — I'd genuinely like to.

— Mikey

MADEZ MEDIA